

WORD PROCESSING



Saylor Academy

Book: Word Processing (Saylor)

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

This text was compiled on 04/22/2026

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

1: Getting Started with Microsoft Word and Google Docs

- 1.1: Microsoft Word Window and Menu Environment
- 1.2: Google Docs Window and Menu Environment

2: Creating and Formatting Documents

- 2.1: Creating Documents
- 2.2: Using and Creating Document Templates
- 2.3: Basic Tools
- 2.4: Basic Formatting Commands

3: Creating Business Documents

- 3.1: What is a Business Letter?
- 3.2: Creating a Block-Style Letter or Memo
- 3.3: Adjusting the Margins and Page Borders of your Business Letter
- 3.4: Creating Headers and Footers for your Business Letter

Index

Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Getting Started with Microsoft Word and Google Docs

In this unit, we discuss the basic on-screen elements of Microsoft Word and Google Docs. We explore the toolbars, menus, commands, and taskbars. Toolbars and menus are located at the top of the screen and list options that allow you to insert, view, or change the layout of a document. Each menu option lists different commands that let you format, save, and print documents. We also discuss the Quick Access Toolbar and learn how to add and delete commands. As you go through this unit, open up your version of Microsoft Word or Google Docs and follow along with the tutorials. This will help you learn as you explore the window and menu environment.

Upon successful completion of this unit, you will be able to:

- open documents in Microsoft Word and Google Docs;
- identify the parts of documents created in Microsoft Word and Google Docs;
- identify each of the menu elements in Microsoft Word and Google Docs; and
- identify and describe important commands in Microsoft Word and Google Docs.

[1.1: Microsoft Word Window and Menu Environment](#)

[1.2: Google Docs Window and Menu Environment](#)

[1: Getting Started with Microsoft Word and Google Docs](#) is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

1.1: Microsoft Word Window and Menu Environment

Microsoft Word is a popular word processing program that is part of the Microsoft Office Suite. Many businesses use it to create, edit, format, and organize documents.

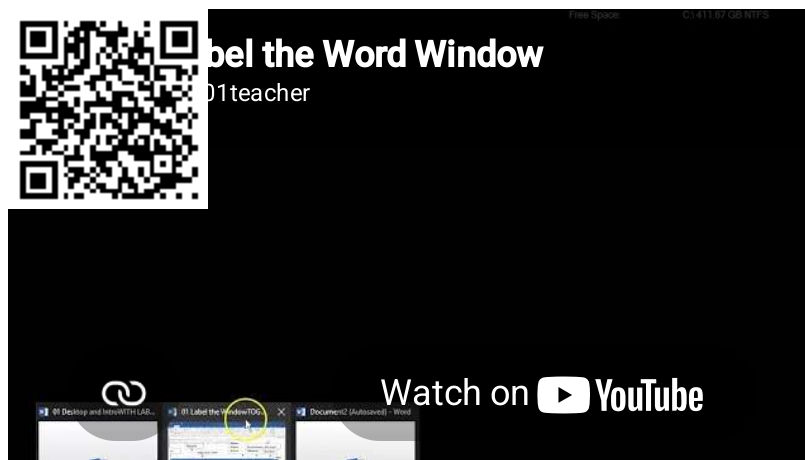
How to Open a Microsoft Word Document

Watch this introductory video to learn how to open a new document, insert text, name your document, use spell check, center your text, change your font, and use the basic navigation tools in Microsoft Word.



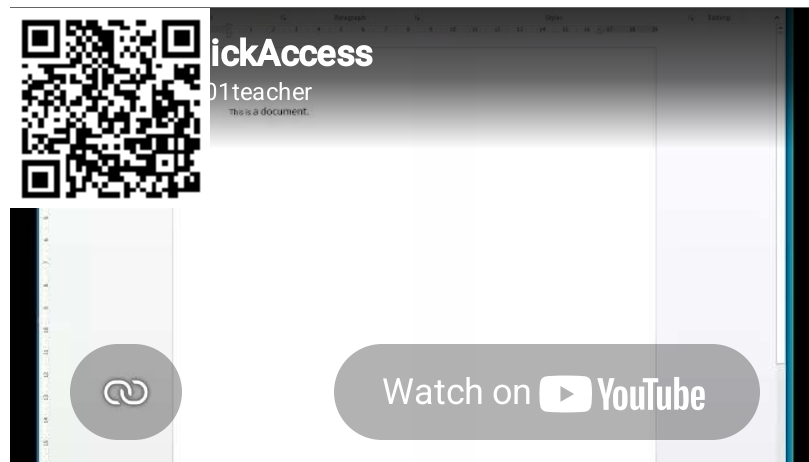
Microsoft Word Layout Basics

Watch this video to explore the Microsoft Word interface, such as the title bar, the task bar, ribbon display options, and the quick access toolbar. The presenter also shows how to maximize and minimize the windows in your screen space.



Microsoft Word's Quick Access Toolbar

Watch this video to learn how to use Microsoft Word's Quick Access toolbar to easily perform common commands.



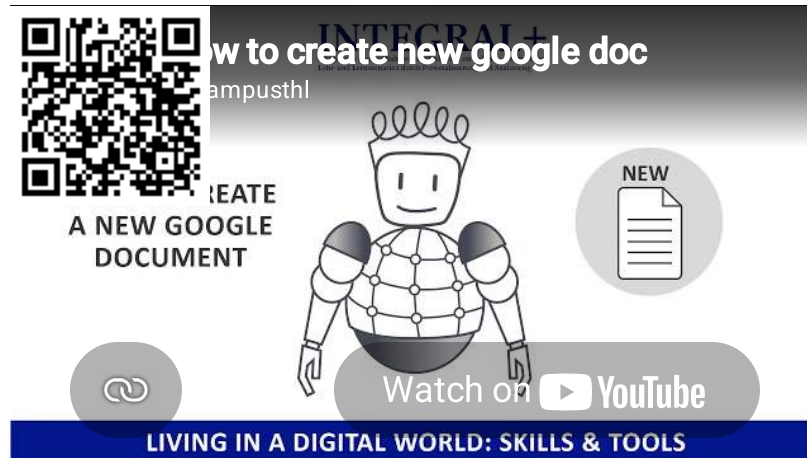
1.1: Microsoft Word Window and Menu Environment is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

1.2: Google Docs Window and Menu Environment

Google Docs is a free web-based word processor offered by Google. Many businesses use it to create, edit, and format documents. Google Docs are especially easy to share online and to collaborate with colleagues. You can access them from anywhere, view and restore older versions of documents if necessary, and allow several users to edit at the same time.

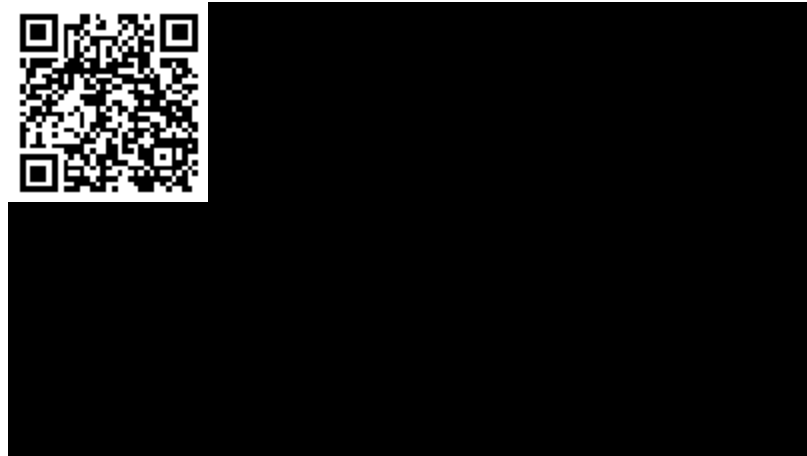
How to Open a Google Docs Document

Watch this brief video for a quick overview of how to open and create a new Google Docs document.



Google Docs Layout Basics

Watch this video on how to navigate the Google Docs interface, including the layout of the menu bar, toolbar, and document area.



1.2: Google Docs Window and Menu Environment is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Creating and Formatting Documents

In this unit, we explore how to use Microsoft Word and Google Docs to create new documents and documents based on templates. We review the different commands used to format documents, and introduce options for saving and printing documents. As with the previous unit, we encourage you to open up your version of Microsoft Word or Google Docs to follow along with the tutorials. This will help you learn as you practice creating and formatting documents.

- Upon successful completion of this unit, you will be able to:
- create a new blank document in Microsoft Word and Google Docs;
- create documents in Microsoft Word and Google Docs using templates;
- use commands such as font, bold, italics, and underline to format text;
- use themes and colors to change the look of a document;
- save and print documents;
- insert images into documents; and
- share a document using Google Doc's sharing tools.

[2.1: Creating Documents](#)

[2.2: Using and Creating Document Templates](#)

[2.3: Basic Tools](#)

[2.4: Basic Formatting Commands](#)

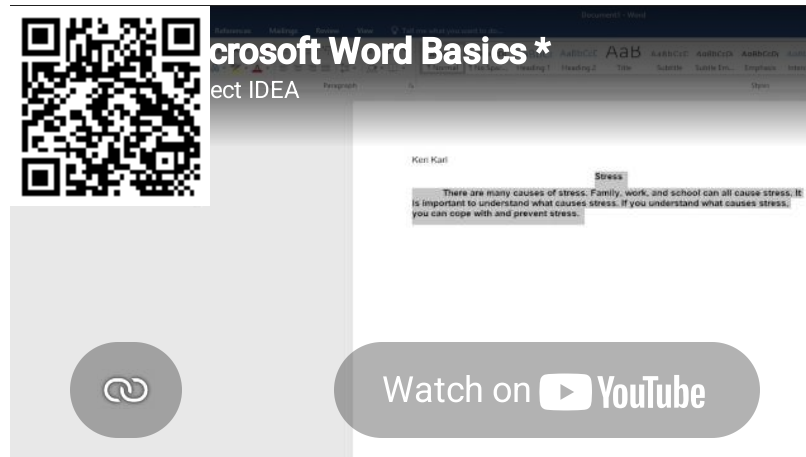
[2: Creating and Formatting Documents](#) is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

2.1: Creating Documents

Now that we have looked into the basic Microsoft Word and Google Docs environment, let's explore how to create a new document. In this section we demonstrate how to use commands to change the font style, such as bold, italics, and underline, and how to save and print your work. We also discuss how you can use themes and colors to change the overall look of your document.

Creating a Microsoft Word Document

Watch this video to learn the basics of how to create a new document in Microsoft Word, add text, and use basic formatting such as bold, italics, and underline.



Creating a Google Docs Document

Watch this video to learn how to create a document in Google Docs, and for a quick tutorial of basic formatting tools, such as how to change the font size of text; add headings, titles, and subtitles; create links to other pages; and rename your document. An advantage of Google Docs is that it saves your work while you are typing and you can review past versions of your document.



2.1: Creating Documents is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

2.2: Using and Creating Document Templates

A template is a pre-designed document you can use as a starting point to create your own document. When you open the template, the fonts, styles, margins, and paragraph settings are already set. For example, one template might include all the formatting elements of a standard business letter, which you would then modify to fit your needs. You can also create your own templates to use later, such as when you need to create the same kind of document over and over.

Microsoft Word Templates

Watch this video to learn how to use and create templates in Microsoft Word. A variety of templates are available, such as for business letters, resumes, and newsletters. You also can save your edits to create your own new template which you can use later. Microsoft Word and Google Docs have document elements you can insert into your template that update automatically, such as the date or time.



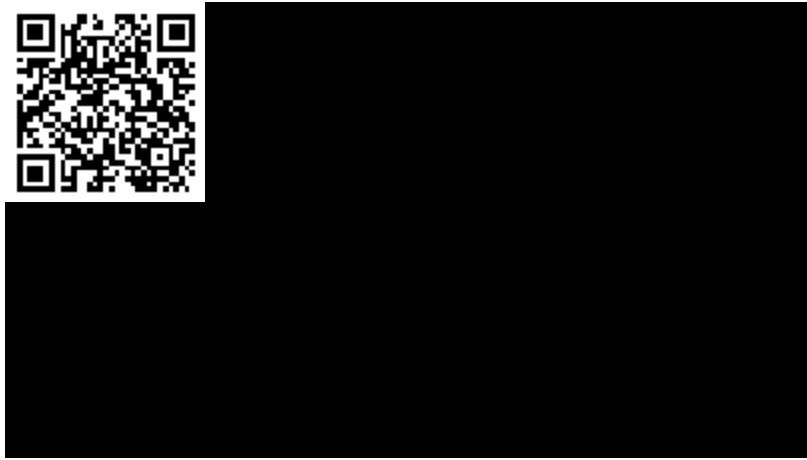
Google Docs Templates

Watch this video to learn how to find, use, and create templates in Google Docs.



More Google Templates

Watch this video to see the gallery of templates available in Google Docs. Note that after timestamp 2:13 this video also looks at some templates in two other Google products, Google Sheets and Google Presentation.



[2.2: Using and Creating Document Templates](#) is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

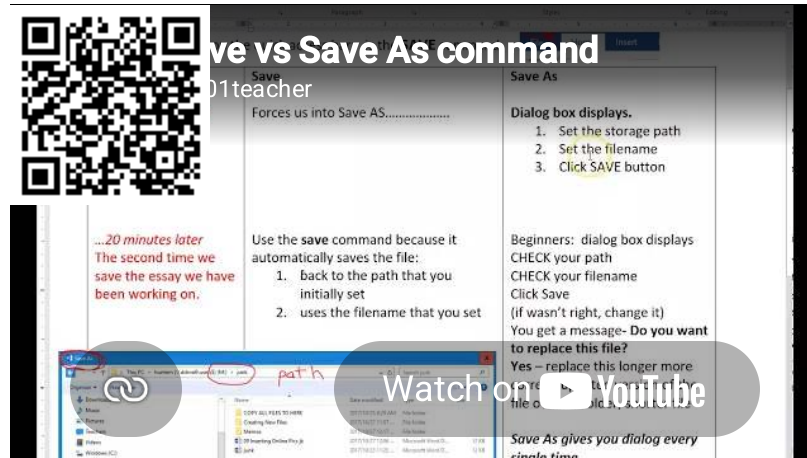
2.3: Basic Tools

Let's dive in and look at several ways to save and print a document, some simple editing tools, how to insert and resize an image, and how to share documents with Google Docs. Microsoft Word and Google Docs make it easy to create and edit documents that look professional and are easy to read.

Note that while some of these videos present commands or features of Google Docs or Microsoft Word, both programs share most of these same basic commands.

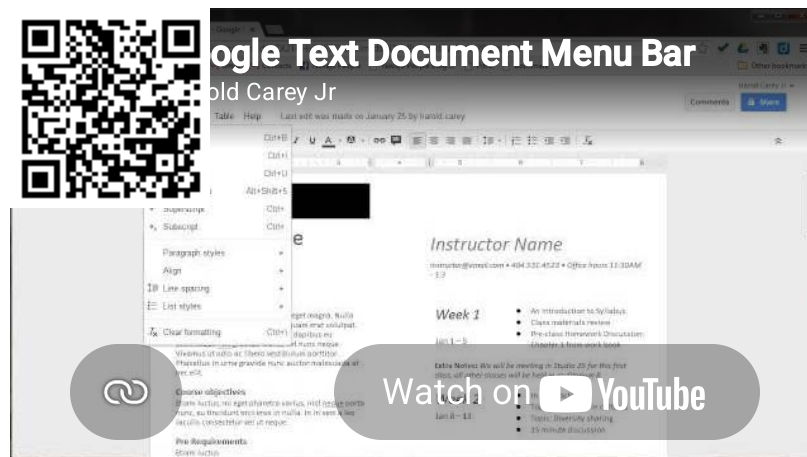
Save and Save As

Watch this video to learn about the difference between the Save and Save As commands, which you can use to replace or create new versions of your document.



Printing in Google Docs

Watch this video learn how to use the print command in Google Docs. The presenter reviews some additional commands on the Google Docs toolbar, such as different style headers which you can use to format the text throughout your document. Note that the version of Google Docs in this video will look different than your version, but the principles are the same.



Printing Selected Text

Watch this video to learn how to print a document or a portion of a document.



Reviewing and Editing

This video discusses the editing features in Google Docs. When you are collaborating with someone in Google Docs, you can make "suggested edits" that allow the document owner to review, accept, or reject your suggestions. The "voice type" tool lets you input text with your voice. You can also use these features on your phone.



Inserting an Image

Watch this video to learn how to insert and resize images you have saved on your computer into Google Docs.



Dragging Pictures

Watch this video to learn how to insert, move, and resize images and pictures in Microsoft Word.



How to drag pictures in Word 2016?

Computer Tutoring



How to drag pictures

Watch on  YouTube

Computer Tutoring

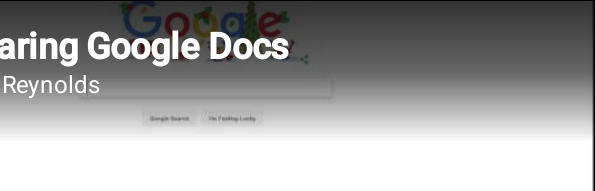
Sharing with Google Docs

This video demonstrates two ways to share documents you create in Google Docs with someone else. Google offers different types of sharing permissions so you can simply allow your work colleagues to view your materials, or you can offer editing permissions so you can all insert comments and suggest edits to collaborate on a single document.



Sharing Google Docs

Reynolds



Watch on  YouTube

2.3: Basic Tools is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

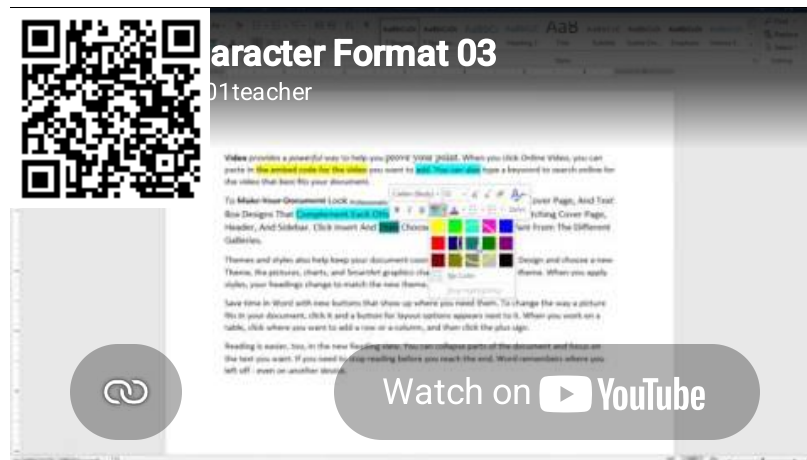
2.4: Basic Formatting Commands

Formatting refers to the appearance of a document. A confusing layout can be frustrating to read and difficult to understand. Documents that are organized and properly formatted are not only easier to read, but you probably want to highlight the data and information you want your audience to see clearly. For example, you may want to showcase how you and your team were able to achieve a difficult sales goal. In this section, we demonstrate how to use Microsoft Word and Google Docs to format documents as you want them to appear.

As we noted in the previous section, while some of these videos present commands or features of Google Docs or Microsoft Word, both programs share most of these same basic commands.

How to Format Your Text

Watch this video to learn about some basic Microsoft Word tools you can use to change the format your text, such as font size, bold, italics, strikethrough, subscript, superscript, and underline.



Using Themes, Fonts, and Colors

Watch this video to learn how to use colors, fonts, and themes to change the appearance of your document.



Character Spacing

Watch this video to learn how to use Microsoft Word's character spacing options.



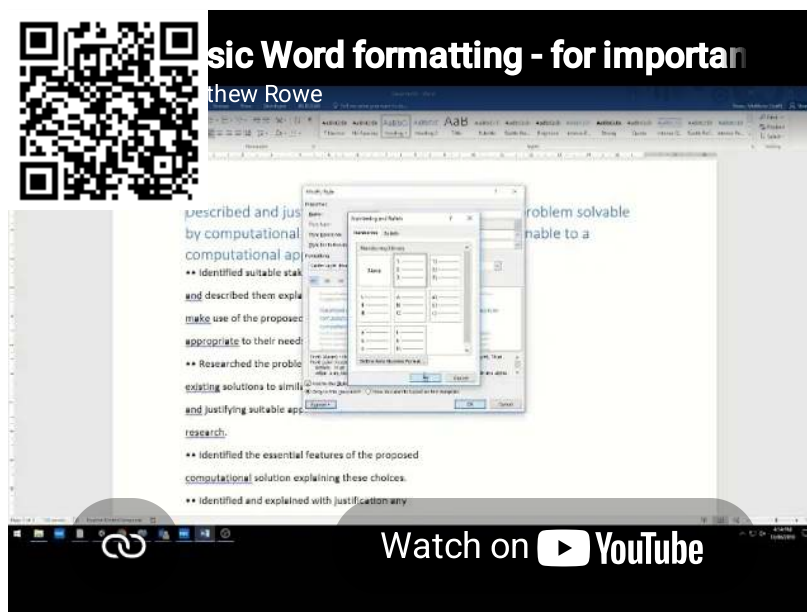
Using Styles

This video demonstrates how to use style commands to easily change the appearance of the text in your document. This formatting technique which is available in Google Docs and Word is especially useful when you create multi-page documents. Your materials will look more organized and are easier-to-read when the font type and spacing for each different level of header shares the same style.



More Tips for Formatting Multi-page Documents

Watch this video to learn some techniques for organizing multi-page Microsoft Word documents, such as using different types of headings, a table of contents, headers, and page numbers. We explore headers and footers in more detail at the end of Unit 3.



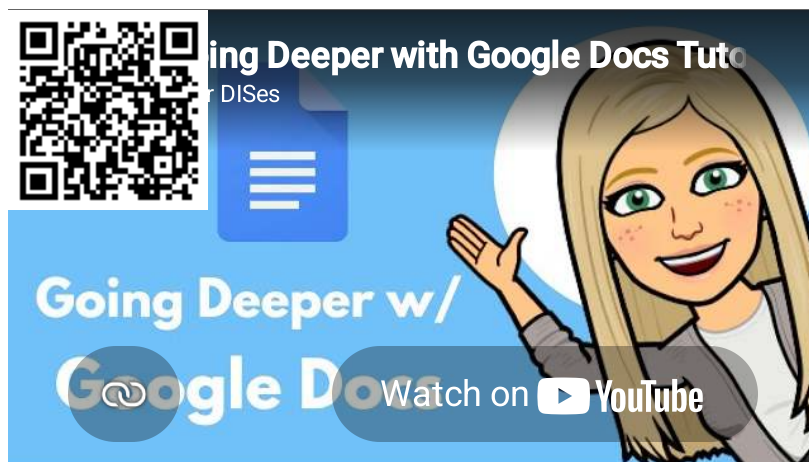
Collaborating with Google Docs

While this tutorial is intended to prepare teachers who plan to use Google Docs to share materials and editing commands with their students, the principles apply to the workplace as well.



More Advanced Google Docs Tools

This tutorial reviews advanced Google Docs features for making documents more visually appealing, such as adding new fonts to your toolbox, inserting media and tables, and using Google's explore panel to find additional resources.



2.4: Basic Formatting Commands is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Creating Business Documents

In this unit, we discuss how to create and format two standard business documents, block-style business letters and memos. Word processing tools allow us to incorporate a variety of font styles to emphasize text. These techniques include creating text that is in bold type, in italics, and underlined. We can also use borders to create a visual break between sections of a document. Finally, we explore how you can add headers and footers to present a polished, professional, and organized business document.

Upon successful completion of this unit, you will be able to:

- outline the elements of a business letter and memo;
- format document margins and adjust spacing between headings and body text;
- add headers, footers, page numbers, and borders to a document;
- create a basic block-style business letter; and
- create a basic block-style business memo.

[3.1: What is a Business Letter?](#)

[3.2: Creating a Block-Style Letter or Memo](#)

[3.3: Adjusting the Margins and Page Borders of your Business Letter](#)

[3.4: Creating Headers and Footers for your Business Letter](#)

3: Creating Business Documents is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3.1: What is a Business Letter?

Many businesses use standard templates and styles for their memos, letters, and emails. Since these formats are standardized, you can use these templates to quickly create business documents in the proper format.

How to Construct a Business LetterPage

Read this handout which discusses business writing and the proper way to format business letters. As you read, think about a work-related letter you have sent or received. Did you or the author follow these guidelines?

What this Handout is About

This handout will help you write business letters required in many different situations, from applying for a job to requesting or delivering information. While the examples that are discussed specifically are the application letter and cover letter, this handout also highlights strategies for effective business writing in general.

Principles to Keep in Mind

Business Writing is Different

Writing for a business audience is usually quite different than writing in the humanities, social sciences, or other academic disciplines. Business writing strives to be crisp and succinct rather than evocative or creative; it stresses specificity and accuracy. This distinction does not make business writing superior or inferior to other styles. Rather, it reflects the unique purpose and considerations involved when writing in a business context.

When you write a business document, you must assume that your audience has limited time in which to read it and is likely to skim. Your readers have an interest in what you say insofar as it affects their working world. They want to know the “bottom line”: the point you are making about a situation or problem and how they should respond.

Business writing varies from the conversational style often found in email messages to the more formal, legalistic style found in contracts. A style between these two extremes is appropriate for the majority of memos, emails, and letters. Writing that is too formal can alienate readers, and an attempt to be overly casual may come across as insincere or unprofessional. In business writing, as in all writing, you must know your audience.

In most cases, the business letter will be the first impression that you make on someone. Though business writing has become less formal over time, you should still take great care that your letter’s content is clear and that you have proofread it carefully.

Pronouns and Active versus Passive Voice

Personal pronouns (like I, we, and you) are important in letters and memos. In such documents, it is perfectly appropriate to refer to yourself as I and to the reader as you. Be careful, however, when you use the pronoun we in a business letter that is written on company stationery, since it commits your company to what you have written. When stating your opinion, use I; when presenting company policy, use we.

The best writers strive to achieve a style that is so clear that their messages cannot be misunderstood. One way to achieve a clear style is to minimize your use of the passive voice. Although the passive voice is sometimes necessary, often it not only makes your writing dull but also can be ambiguous or overly impersonal. Here’s an example of the same point stated in passive voice and in the active voice:

Passive voice: “The net benefits of subsidiary divestiture were grossly overestimated.”

[Who did the overestimating?]

Active voice: The Global Finance Team grossly overestimated the net benefits of subsidiary divestiture.

The second version is clearer and thus preferable.

Of course, there are exceptions to every rule. What if you are the head of the Global Finance Team? You may want to get your message across without calling excessive attention to the fact that the error was your team’s fault. The passive voice allows you to gloss over an unflattering point—but you should use it sparingly.

Focus and Specificity

Business writing should be clear and concise. Take care, however, that your document does not turn out as an endless series of short, choppy sentences. Keep in mind also that “concise” does not have to mean “blunt”—you still need to think about your tone and the audience for whom you are writing. Consider the following examples:

After carefully reviewing this proposal, we have decided to prioritize other projects this quarter.
Nobody liked your project idea, so we are not going to give you any funding.

The first version is a weaker statement, emphasizing facts not directly relevant to its point. The second version provides the information in a simple and direct manner. But you don’t need to be an expert on style to know that the first phrasing is diplomatic and respectful (even though it’s less concise) as compared with the second version, which is unnecessarily harsh and likely to provoke a negative reaction.

Business Letters: Where to Begin

Reread the description of your task (for example, the advertisement of a job opening, instructions for a proposal submission, or assignment prompt for a course). Think about your purpose and what requirements are mentioned or implied in the description of the task. List these requirements. This list can serve as an outline to govern your writing and help you stay focused, so try to make it thorough. Next, identify qualifications, attributes, objectives, or answers that match the requirements you have just listed. Strive to be exact and specific, avoiding vagueness, ambiguity, and platitudes. If there are industry- or field-specific concepts or terminology that are relevant to the task at hand, use them in a manner that will convey your competence and experience. Avoid any language that your audience may not understand. Your finished piece of writing should indicate how you meet the requirements you’ve listed and answer any questions raised in the description or prompt.

Application Letters and Cover Letters

Many people believe that application letters and cover letters are essentially the same. For purposes of this handout, though, these kinds of letters are different. The letter of application is a sales letter in which you market your skills, abilities, and knowledge. A cover letter, on the other hand, is primarily a document of transmittal. It identifies an item being sent, the person to whom it is being sent, and the reason for its being sent, and provides a permanent record of the transmittal for both the writer and the reader.

Application Letters

When writing an application letter, remember that you probably have competition. Your audience is a professional who screens and hires job applicants—someone who may look through dozens or even hundreds of other applications on the day she receives yours. The immediate objective of your application letter and accompanying resume is to attract this person’s attention. Your ultimate goal is to obtain an interview.

As you write your application letter, be sure you complete three tasks: catch the reader’s attention favorably, convince the reader that you are a qualified candidate for the job, and request an interview.

Application Letter Checklist:

- Identify the job by title and let the recipient know how you heard about it.
- Summarize your qualifications for the job, specifically your work experience, activities that show your leadership skills, and your educational background.
- Refer the reader to your enclosed resume.
- Ask for an interview, stating where you can be reached and when you will be available. If your prospective employer is located in another city and you plan to visit the area, mention the dates for your trip.
- If you are applying for a specific job, include any information pertinent to the position that is not included in your resume.

To save your reader time and to call attention to your strengths as a candidate, state your objective directly at the beginning of the letter.

I am seeking a position as a manager in your Data Center. In such a management position, I can use my master’s degree in information systems and my experience as a programmer/analyst to address business challenges in data processing.

If you have been referred to a company by one of its employees, a career counselor, a professor, or someone else, mention that before stating your job objective.

Example:

I am seeking a position as a manager in your Data Center. In such a management position, I can use my master's degree in information systems and my experience as a programmer/analyst to address business challenges in data processing.

If you have been referred to a company by one of its employees, a career counselor, a professor, or someone else, mention that before stating your job objective.

Example:

During the recent ARRGH convention in Washington, D.C., one of your sales representatives, Dusty Brown, informed me of a possible opening for a manager in your Data Center. My extensive background in programming and my master's degree in information systems make me highly qualified for the position.

In subsequent paragraphs, expand on the qualifications you mentioned in your opening. Add any appropriate details, highlighting experience listed on your resume that is especially pertinent to the job you are seeking. Close with a request for an interview. Proofread your letter carefully.

Two sample letters of application are presented below. The first letter (Sample Number 1) is by a recent college graduate responding to a local newspaper article about the company's plan to build a new computer center. The writer is not applying for a specific job opening but describes the position he seeks. The second letter (Sample Number 2) is from a college senior who does not specify where she learned of the opening because she is uncertain whether a position is available.

Sample Number 1

6123 Farrington Road, Apt. B11
Chapel Hill, NC 27514

January 11, 2005

Taylor, Inc.
694 Rockstar Lane
Durham, NC 27708

Dear Human Resources Director:

I just read an article in the News and Observer about Taylor's new computer center just north of Durham. I would like to apply for a position as an entry-level programmer at the center.

I understand that Taylor produces both in-house and customer documentation. My technical writing skills, as described in the enclosed resume, are well suited to your company. I am a recent graduate of DeVry Institute of Technology in Atlanta with an Associate's Degree in Computer Science. In addition to having taken a broad range of courses, I served as a computer consultant at the college's computer center where I helped train users to work with new systems.

I will be happy to meet with you at your convenience and discuss how my education and experience match your needs. You can reach me at my home address, at (919) 233-1552, or at krock@devry.alumni.edu.

Sincerely,

Raymond Krock

Sample Number 2

6123 Farrington Road, Apt. G11
Chapel Hill, NC 27514

January 11, 2005

Taylor, Inc.
694 Rockstar Lane
Durham, NC 27708

Dear Ms. Jones:

I am seeking a position in your engineering department where I may use my training in computer sciences to solve Taylor's engineering problems. I would like to be a part of the department that developed the Internet Selection System but am unsure whether you have a current opening.

I expect to receive a Bachelor of Science degree in Engineering from North Carolina State University in June and by that time will have completed the Computer Systems Engineering Program. Since September 2000, I have been participating, through the University, in the Professional Training Program at Computer Systems International in Raleigh. In the program I was assigned to several staff sections as an apprentice. Most recently, I have been a programmer trainee in the Engineering Department and have gained a great deal of experience in computer applications. Details of the academic courses I have taken are included in the enclosed resume.

If there is a position open at Taylor Inc., please let me know whom I should contact for further information. I look forward to hearing from you soon. I may be reached at my office (919-866-4000 ext. 232) or via email (Brock@aol.com).

Sincerely,

Rebecca Brock

Cover Letters

As mentioned previously, application letters and cover letters are not the same. A cover letter identifies an item being sent, the person to whom it is being sent, and the reason for its being sent. A cover letter provides a permanent record of the transmittal for both the writer and the reader.

In a cover letter, keep your remarks brief. Your opening should explain what you are sending and why. In an optional second paragraph, you might include a summary of the information you are sending. A letter accompanying a proposal, for example, might point out sections in the proposal that might be of particular interest to the reader. The letter could then go on to present a key point or two explaining why the writer's firm is the best one for the job. The closing paragraph should contain acknowledgements, offer additional assistance, or express the hope that the material will fulfill its purpose.

The following are examples of cover letters. The first letter (Sample Number 1) is brief and to the point. The second letter (Sample Number 2) is slightly more detailed because it touches on the manner in which the information was gathered.

Sample Number 1

Your Company Logo and Contact Information

January 11, 2005

Brian Eno, Chief Engineer
Carolina Chemical Products
3434 Pond View Lane
Durham, NC 27708

Dear Mr. Eno:

Enclosed is the final report on our installment of pollution control equipment at Eastern Chemical Company, which we send with Eastern's Permission. Please call me collect (ext. 1206) or email me at the address below if I can answer any questions.

Sincerely,

Nora Cassidy
Technical Services Manager
ncassidy@company.com

Sample Number 2

Your Company Logo and Contact Information

January 11, 2005

Brian Eno, Chief Engineer

Ecology Systems, Inc.

8458 Obstructed View Lane

Durham, NC 27708

Dear Mr. Eno:

Enclosed is the report estimating our power consumption for the year as requested by John Brenan, Vice President, on September 4.

The report is the result of several meetings with Jamie Anson, Manager of Plant Operations, and her staff and an extensive survey of all our employees. The survey was delayed by the transfer of key staff in Building A. We believe, however, that the report will provide the information you need to furnish us with a cost estimate for the installation of your Mark II Energy Saving System.

We would like to thank Billy Budd of ESI for his assistance in preparing the survey. If you need more information, please let me know.

Sincerely,

Nora Cassidy

New Projects Office

ncassidy@company.com

Enclosure: Report

Works Consulted

We consulted these works while writing this handout. This is not a comprehensive list of resources on the handout's topic, and we encourage you to do your own research to find the latest publications on this topic. Please do not use this list as a model for the format of your own reference list, as it may not match the citation style you are using.

- Covey, Stephen R. *FranklinCovey Style Guide for Business and Technical Writing*. 5th ed. Upper Saddle River, N.J.: Franklin Covey, 2012.
- *Business and Administrative Communication*. Boston: McGraw-Hill, 2012.
- Source: The Writing Center, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, <https://writingcenter.unc.edu/tips-and-tools/business-letters/>

How to Construct a Business MemoPage

Read this chapter to learn how to formulate a business memo or email.

Memos

A memo (or memorandum, meaning “reminder”) is normally used for communicating policies, procedures, or related official business within an organization. It is often written from a one-to-all perspective (like mass communication), broadcasting a message to an audience, rather than a one-on-one, interpersonal communication. It may also be used to update a team on activities for a given project or to inform a specific group within a company of an event, action, or observance.

Memo Purpose

A memo's purpose is often to inform and represent the business or organization's interests, but it occasionally includes an element of persuasion or a call to action. All organizations have informal and formal communication networks. The unofficial, informal

communication network within an organization is often called the grapevine, and it is often characterized by rumor, gossip, and innuendo. On the grapevine, one person may hear that someone else is going to be laid off and start passing the news around. Rumors change and transform as they are passed from person to person, and before you know it, the word is that they are shutting down your entire department.

One effective way to address informal, unofficial speculation is to spell out clearly for all employees what is going on with a particular issue. If budget cuts are a concern, then it may be wise to send a memo explaining the changes that are imminent. If a company wants employees to take action, they may also issue a memorandum.

Memo Format

A memo has a header with guide words that clearly indicate who sent the memo, who the intended recipients are, the date of the memo, and a descriptive subject line. The content of each guide word field aligns. The message then follows the header, and it typically includes a declaration (introduction), a discussion, and a summary.

Figure 4.1.1 shows a sample memo.

To: All employees From: Larry Ogawa, IT Manager, The Widget Research Company Date: June 15, 2018 Subject: New photocopier installations – July 5 On July 5, new photocopiers will be installed in the photocopier room on each floor. The installation will take place from 8:30 – 11:30 a.m. During this time, printing, scanning, and photocopying will not be available. The old photocopiers will be disconnected from the network on the morning of July 5. Technicians will be on-site to simultaneously install the new machines on every floor in order to minimize printing downtime. The new photocopiers have all of the same functionality as the ones they are replacing but will be faster and quieter. Training sessions will be organized so all employees can learn how to use the new machines. More details about these training sessions will be shared by the end of this month. Please direct any questions or concerns to me.
--

Figure 4.1.1. A sample memo (Melissa Ashman, 2018, [CC-BY-NC 4.0 international license](#))

Five Tips for Effective Business Memos

1. Audience Orientation

Always consider the audience and their needs when preparing a memo (or any message for that matter). An acronym or abbreviation that is known to management may not be known by all the employees of the organization, and if the memo is to be posted and distributed within the organization, the goal is to be clear and concise communication at all levels with no ambiguity.

2. Professional Tone

Memos are often announcements, and the person sending the memo speaks for a part or all of the organization. Use a professional tone at all times.

3. Subject Emphasis

The topic of the memo is normally declared in the subject line, and it should be clear, concise, and descriptive. If the memo is announcing the observance of a holiday, for example, the specific holiday should be named in the subject line—for example, use “Thanksgiving weekend schedule” rather than “holiday observance.”

4. Direct Format

Some written business communication allows for a choice between direct and indirect formats, but memorandums are almost always direct. The purpose is clearly announced immediately and up-front, and the explanation or supporting information then follows.

5. Maintain Objectivity

3.1: What is a Business Letter? is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3.2: Creating a Block-Style Letter or Memo

When creating the basic block-style that many offices use for their emails, memos, and letters, be sure to pay attention to spacing between paragraphs and words, since it is an important component of block-style documents.

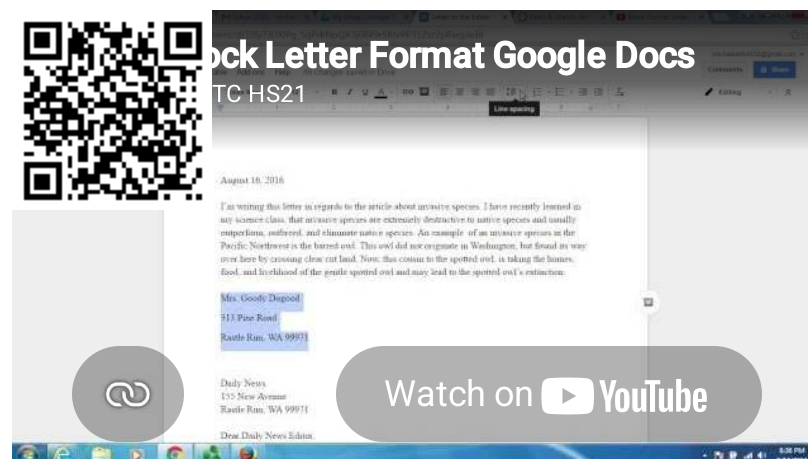
How to Create a Block-Style Letter in Microsoft Word

Watch this video for a tutorial on how to create a block-style letter using Microsoft Word.



How to Create a Block-Style Letter in Google Docs

This video demonstrates how to create a block-style letter using Google Docs.



Block-Style Memos

Watch this video to learn how to create a block-style business memo.



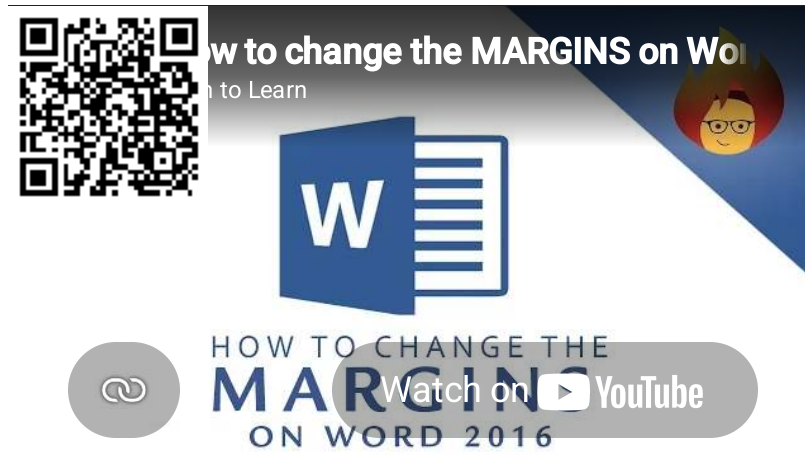
3.2: Creating a Block-Style Letter or Memo is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3.3: Adjusting the Margins and Page Borders of your Business Letter

Margins are the space between the text and edge of a document. By default, margins in Microsoft Word and Google Docs are set to one inch from the right, top, left, and bottom of the page. You may want to adjust the page margins if, for example, your company uses a logo at the top of the page. We can use page borders to customize documents with background colors and shading. You can apply a border to an entire page, a paragraph, or a section of text.

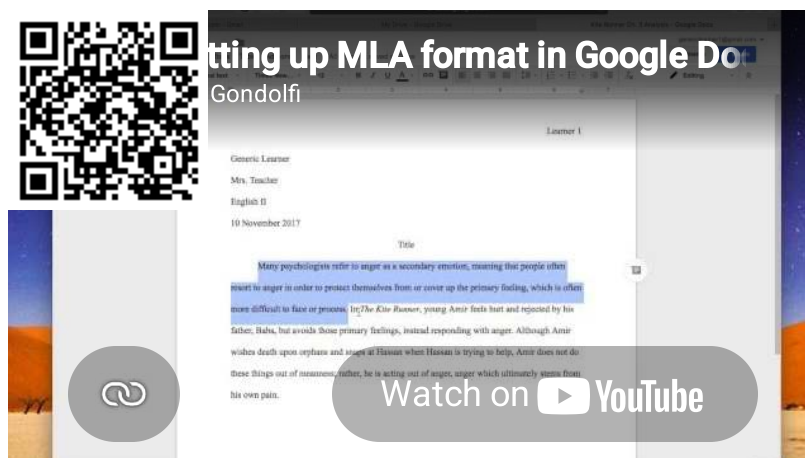
Margins in Microsoft Word

This video demonstrates how to change the margins in Microsoft Word.



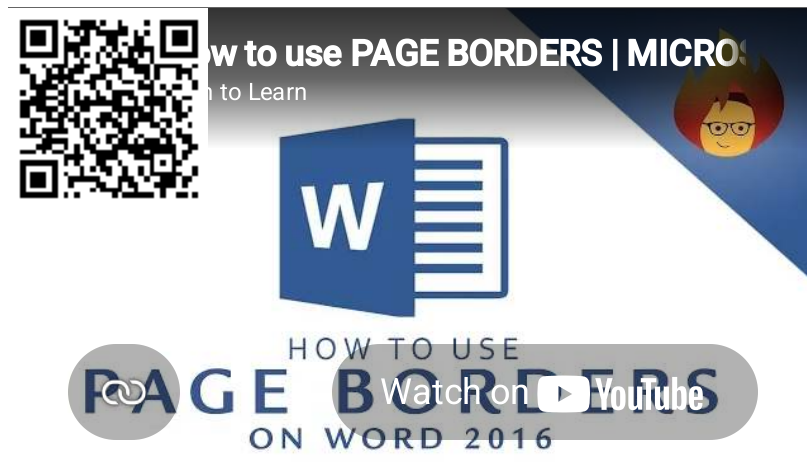
Margins in Google Docs

While this video focuses on how to set up MLA formatting, it also shows how to adjust the page margins in Google Docs. Note that scholars use three main style conventions to format their documents depending on the subject matter: APA (American Psychological Association), MLA (Modern Language Association), and Chicago Manual of Style.



Page Borders

Watch this brief video to learn how to add page borders to document.



3.3: Adjusting the Margins and Page Borders of your Business Letter is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3.4: Creating Headers and Footers for your Business Letter

This section focuses on how to use headers and footers which we often use when creating documents that have multiple pages. For example, they may contain information, such as the author's name, date and time, or page numbers. As their names suggest, headers appear at the top of a document, while footers appear at the bottom.

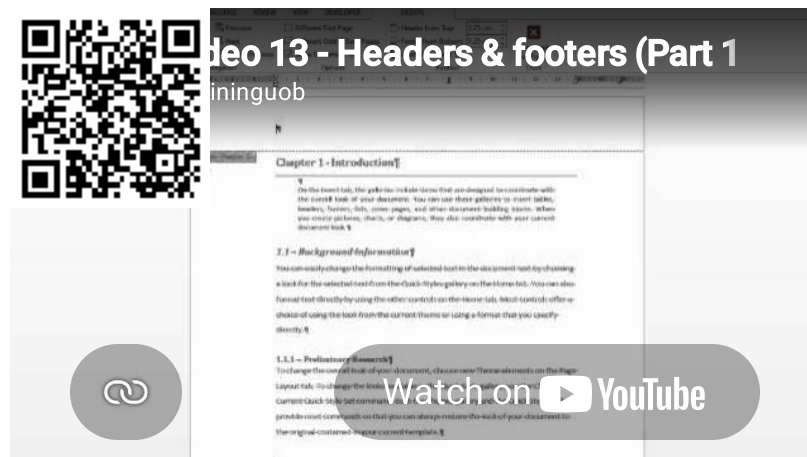
Headers and Footers in Google Docs

Watch this video to learn how to create headers and footers in Google Docs.



Headers and Footers in Microsoft Word

Watch this video to learn how to create headers and footers in Microsoft Word.



3.4: Creating Headers and Footers for your Business Letter is shared under a [CC BY 3.0](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

Index

D

dire

Glossary

Sample Word 1 | Sample Definition 1

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [Word Processing \(Saylor\)](#)

Webpages: 23

All licenses found:

- [CC BY 3.0](#): 95.7% (22 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 4.3% (1 page)

By Page

- [Word Processing \(Saylor\)](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [1: Getting Started with Microsoft Word and Google Docs](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [1.1: Microsoft Word Window and Menu Environment](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [1.2: Google Docs Window and Menu Environment](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [2: Creating and Formatting Documents](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [2.1: Creating Documents](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [2.2: Using and Creating Document Templates](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [2.3: Basic Tools](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [2.4: Basic Formatting Commands](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [3: Creating Business Documents](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [3.1: What is a Business Letter?](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [3.2: Creating a Block-Style Letter or Memo](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [3.3: Adjusting the Margins and Page Borders of your Business Letter](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [3.4: Creating Headers and Footers for your Business Letter](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [CC BY 3.0](#)